Where I Come From

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'Where I Come From'

Here is a detailed guide to Elizabeth Brewster's poem 'Where I Come From', which can be found in the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line "translation" of the poem's meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods**: an exploration of Brewster's poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of themes and ideas within Brewster's poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Brewster's intention and message

'Where I Come From' overview

Elizabeth Brewster's poem 'Where I Come From' examines the influence of place and environment on individual identity. It begins by explaining how sensory experiences leave an impression on people all over the world, and develops into a nostalgic memory about the speaker's own home.

'Where I Come From' breakdown

Lines 1–3

> **"People are made of places. They carry with them hints of jungles or mountains, a tropic grace or the cool eyes of sea gazers. Atmosphere of cities"**

Translation

aspects ("hints") of places such as "grace" (elegance) from tropical jungles, or "cool" eyes from watching the ocean

Brewster's intentions

- Brewster establishes the theme of the poem: individual identity is shaped by places
- She describes people with metaphor connoting to habitats, such as those with a "tropic grace" or eyes "cool" from the ocean:
  - This presents humans and natural environments as intrinsically linked

Lines 4-8

> **"how different drops from them, like the smell of smog**
> **or the almost-not-smell of tulips in the spring,**
> **nature tidily plotted in little squares**
> **with a fountain in the centre; museum smell**
> **Art also tidily plotted with a guidebook;"**

Translation

- The poem describes the atmosphere of a city, with the absence of nature's smell
- She implies the smells of a city are different, and that cities divide nature into neat squares with fountains in the middle, or like museums which organise art into neat blocks complete with a guidebook

Brewster's intentions

- Brewster implies that the city tries to control nature:
  - The metaphorical "nature tidily plotted" describes a man-made environment
  - In a city, everything has a place, suggesting the urban environment tries to control its inhabitants too and tries to restrict spontaneity and wildness
- The alliteration of "different drops" emphasises a key theme, that places leave impressions on people, no matter how different they are
- The repetition of "smell" reinforces the importance of this sense

Lines 9-11

> **"or the smell of work, glue factories maybe,**
> **chromium-plated offices; smell of subways**
> **crowded at rush hours."**

Translation

"factories", "offices", and commuters in subways during "rush hours"

Brewster's intentions

- Brewster uses sensory imagery to describe nature in an urban setting: the smell of "work" and man-made materials
- She presents city life as busy, suggesting the environment makes people feel hurried

Lines 12-17

> **" Where I come from, people**
> **carry woods in their minds, acres of pine woods;**
> **blueberry patches in the burned-out bush;**
> **wooden farmhouses, old, in need of paint,**
> **with yards where hens and chickens circle about**
> **clucking aimlessly; battered schoolhouses"**

Translation

- The poem moves to describing the speaker's own home: where she comes from the people have forests in their "minds", implying nature is part of their psyche or identity
- A list of descriptions of a rural location (a run-down busy farm) describe her home:
  - There are "battered schoolhouses", and hens "clucking" near "burned-out" bushes and "blueberry patches"

Brewster's intentions

- Brewster brings the focus inward as she considers how her identity has been influenced by a rural upbringing:
  - She creates a sense of bustling energy to present a happy, busy environment
  - A nostalgic tone presents memories of home as relaxed amongst nature
  - She creates a sensory contrast with the human creations previously described

- Brewster shows how past experiences of places become ingrained in memory

Lines 18-19

> **"behind which violets grow. Spring and winter**
> **are the mind's chief seasons: ice and the breaking of ice."**

Translation

seasons so memorable

Brewster's intentions

- Brewster describes memories that suggest the impact of one's heritage on identity
- The repetition of "ice" implies memories of home centre around sensual feeling

Lines 20–21

> **"A door in the mind blows open, and there blows a frosty wind from fields of snow."**

Translation

- The last lines of the poem describe memory as a "door in the mind":
  - In the speaker's memory it is like they can feel the "frosty wind" again

Brewster's intentions

- Brewster's poem portrays how memories can be triggered by weather and habitat:
  - A metaphor symbolises memory as a "door" to the past
  - Brewster uses the word "mind" here, and elsewhere in the poem, to connect place with thought
- Repetition of "blow" presents memory as an intense and with a sudden "frosty wind"

Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for the poetry question in CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes. Specifically, examiners reward a personal engagement with the poem's "deeper meanings". This means you should spend more time thinking about, for example, the reason Brewster describes two different settings in her poem. Ask yourself **why** the poet has created a certain effect, and what ideas are conveyed as a result.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's

and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Brewster's intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Brewster's poem is a reflection on how places influence individuals; particularly how they form part of our identity as they become memories.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intentions
Humans and nature	The poem, made up of three irregular stanzas, progresses a reader through a reflection on varied settings: the first stanza examines the world and cities, while the second and third stanzas become a personal recollection of the speaker's rural home	Brewster's poem is, initially, an examination of how environments affect individuals, especially in the chaos of city life, but its subjective ending about a past life reveals a speaker caught up in their own memories of a significant place, as if to prove her point

Structure

Brewster's poem is informal with no pattern of metre or rhyme, which contributes to its reflective subject matter about memories of places, and the impressions they leave on individuals.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem is a rambling reflection that uses enjambment and a conversational style to present an unplanned exploration of place and identity	Brewster's unpredictable and chaotic style contributes to the idea that individual identity is shaped by random sensory experiences which trigger the memories of places

Language

Brewster describes places through sensory experiences, such as smell, texture, colour, and weather to show how places

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	Using sibilance the poet emphasises the intensity of city life ("smell of smog"), which is contrasted with a vibrant image of rural life that includes extremes such as "violets" and "ice" while simultaneously portraying it as a relaxed lifestyle through onomatopoeia like "clucking aimlessly"	Brewster suggests that city life is intense, and shapes us in terms of career, whereas rural places offer a simpler life and are part of our heritage
Individual identity	Sensory imagery describes the intense impressions of places on people: smells such as "glue", textures like "chromium-plated offices", weather like "a frosty wind", or colours like "blueberry"	Brewster implies that memories and identities are formed from the sensory nature of places we live in

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore** the **writer's intentions and methods**.

This section has been divided into two main themes that Brewster explores in 'Where I Come From':

- Urban and rural settings
- Individual identity

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners ask for a "personal and evaluative engagement". The best way to achieve this is to engage with the key words of the question, and think carefully about your introduction. It is a good idea to avoid beginning with biographical or historical facts about the poet or the time in which the poem was written, unless you link it to how the poet covers this as a theme. You could write, for instance: "Brewster explores how memories shape individual identity in her personal poem, and reflects on her own Canadian heritage in her description of a cold and rural setting".

- Elizabeth Brewster, born in 1922, grew up in a rural Canadian logging town
- The poem 'Where I Come From' appears in her 1977 book Sometimes I Think of Moving, which covers themes of place, often about her home in New Brunswick:
  - In this poem, Brewster emphasises a cold setting with the repetition of "ice and the breaking of ice", and a final line "frosty wind from fields of snow"
  - The rural setting which she describes as her childhood home portrays a wilderness of "acres of pine"

Individual identity

- Brewster is considered a modernist poet whose work focuses on landscapes and environments, and how personal heritage shapes individual identity
- Her poetry often employs conversational speakers who use simple imagery:
  - The poem 'Where I Come From' uses simple descriptions, such as "burned-out bush" or "breaking of ice"
  - Simple metaphor such as "cool eyes" maintains a simplistic style
- The influence of other modernist poets may be found in Brewster's unpredictable, rambling structure that follows no regular rhythm or rhyme

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: what the question is asking and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated model answer.

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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